PRELUDE XI

THIS is a mass of four-part and five-part harmony built up mainly by a single melodic figure (*e, f, g, f*) and its inversion, which floats all over the key-board leaving sustained notes in its wake. The chords thus left floating sounded clear and ethereal on the clavichord, and they sound clearest on the pianoforte when the ethereal quality is aimed at. Swells are of great aid in the approach to a long note, as accounting for its receiving enough tone to last its time; but anything like a *forte* or even a *mezzo-forte* is merely destructive to the harmony and quite uninteresting as a musical conception. There need be no lack of necessary variety if this piece is played with a clear sense of its form, as may be shown by taking a new "breath" at the beginning of each important period—that is to say, not at every eight bars, but first after bar 16; then, with a sense of the rise of an important development, after bar 40; lastly, with a slight *ritardando*, at bar 56, marking the return to the tonic with the first sixteen bars recapitulated with a slight change of harmony that keeps in the tonic what was formerly in the dominant. (As there is a great danger from any temptation to force the tone, there is much to be said for making this recapitulation stand out as *pianissimo;* though, of course, this is a mere optional suggestion that has been found to answer well.) The smaller periods will mark themselves distinctly enough if these main divisions are duly regarded; and variety of tone-colour will be greatly helped by proper attention to the rests (*e.g.*, in the bass of bar 12), so that the ear may become sensitive to open spaces in the harmony.

The slurs in bar 1 are authenticated, and they mark with a caressing touch the phrasing for those places where the figure moves in one voice without leaving sustained notes behind. They should therefore be applied in bars 10-11, 17, and many other places which may readily be found. The *appoggiatura* in bar 66 is written by Bach (as always, except when he uses the *Häkchen*) as a small type quaver, which may mean anything. A minim (as suggested here) is *en règle*, and gives the best harmonic value, but a crotchet is also good.

FUGUE XI

IT is difficult to hold this high-spirited Fugue back in its precipitous course. The demisemiquavers in bars 90-93 are brilliant clavichord or harpsichord runs, and can put no restraint on the *tempo*. Nor are the big chords in bars 85-87 (which should burst out with an abrupt harp-like attack) more than an occasion for a momentary broadening of a *tempo* that is not calculated for them. The real danger of letting the music bolt away is shown by the important cadence-passage in the dominant, bars 25-29, with its enhanced recapitulation in the tonic at the end (exact as regards the bass) bars 95-99; and the *not* brilliant demisemiquavers in bar 45 also impose restraint. The last note of the Fugue is deliberately written so as to prove that Bach

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desires an abrupt end, so that we cannot compromise on more than the slightest *ritardando* for the cadence-passage—*i.e.*, it has just as much room for broadening as the harp-like chords of bars 86-87. The inference, then, is a two-in-a-bar gait, rolling along in high spirits with plenty of accent (witness Bach's own *staccato* dots) and a disposition to loll but never to drag.

The events in this Fugue (as in its equally comic and unencumbered neighbours, the E minor and F minor Fugues) are the entries of its Subject. These are separated by very long Episodes, which add greatly to their importance. Episode 1 intervenes in bars 9-14 before the third voice has entered; and, in its chain of three-beat imitations across the two-beat bars, is a comic version of the sublime device at the corresponding point in the B♭ minor Fugue of Book I. (Such Aristophanic parodies imply the same poetic power as their originals.) Episode 2 (bars 18-21) is a quite short imitative dialogue on bars 3-4 of the Subject, with an allusion to the jerky counterpoint (not a definite Countersubject) of bars 5-8. This completes the episodic material. Episode 3 fills twenty-two bars, without counting the previous formal cadence of bars 25-29; so that the re-entry of the Subject (unexpected in spite of the long absence) in bar 52 will be very emphatic. Episode 4 (bars 57-66) gravitates towards the subdominant, where it stands on its dignity (or, if you prefer technicalities, on a dominant pedal) till the Subject appears in that key; and the next Episode (bars 70-85) boldly goes into the ultra-subdominant region of E♭ in order to work round to a still more dignified and declamatory pedal on the dominant of F minor, probably the only point in this Fugue which Cherubini would have considered orthodox in a Fugue which gets along so well with only three of his " eight essentials." We need not share Cherubini's inexpressible horror at the collision between D♮ and D♭ in bar 84; it merely serves to prevent us from making too solemn a *ritardando* on approaching the outburst in bars 85-88. After this triumphant soprano entry of the Subject the bass answers, but, either failing or refusing to take wide enough steps, makes four bars out of the first two before it can get on with the second figure. It then concludes with the cadential sequence of bars 25-29.